

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: Period horizon and source method

LATER VEDIC BACKGROUND -> c. 600-400 BCE CORE -> c. 600-200 BCE WIDER HORIZON

agrarian and varna change      Buddha-age polities      textual redaction and urban growth  
SOURCES: Nikayas/Vinaya + Jaina texts + Dharmasutras/Panini + archaeology

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Do not make unlike sources exactly contemporary.

METHOD: claim -> named source/site -> what it proves -> transmission limit.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: From jana to territorial state

KIN COMMUNITY / JANA

- > settled territory / JANAPADA
- > larger competing MAHAJANAPADAS
- > monarchies and gana-sanghas

MECHANISMS: revenue + army + fortified centres + officials + diplomacy

RESULT: political authority became more territorial and extractive.

LIMIT: change was regionally uneven and did not erase clan structures.

TRAP: gana-sangha was restricted oligarchy, not modern democracy.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: Second urbanisation as a system

AGRARIAN SURPLUS -> SPECIALISED CRAFTS -> EXCHANGE -> TOWNS

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state demand <- taxes, armies, officials <- merchants and householders
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      +----- roads + rivers + coin use -----+
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Urbanisation was a network of production, power and circulation.

NBPW is an associated material horizon, not the single cause of towns.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Agrarian base, iron and revenue

FOREST CLEARANCE + PLOUGH AGRICULTURE + LABOUR

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larger and more regular surplus

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shares, tribute, labour dues and market-related extraction

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treasury -> officials -> army -> territorial competition

CAUTION: iron enabled tools and weapons but did not mechanically create states.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: State institutions and differentiated offices

RAJAN / RULING LINEAGE

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ministers and mahamattas -> revenue and judicial functions

army and commanders -> coercion and defence

village heads -> local mediation and collection

envoys and alliances -> interstate competition

Office terms show functional differentiation, not a uniform Mauryan bureaucracy.

Capacity = resources + information + compliance, not titles alone.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Varna norm and social practice

### BRAHMANICAL NORM

fourfold ranked varna  
duty and ritual status  
prescriptive texts

### LIVED SOCIAL FIELD

occupations, jatis, clans and regions  
wealth, power, mobility and exclusion  
Buddhist/Jaina texts + archaeology

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\-- NEGOTIATION ---/

Varna organised claims to hierarchy; it did not fully describe every social relation.  
Neither timeless rigidity nor unrestricted mobility is evidence-safe.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Householders, merchants, labour and dependency

GAHAPATI: substantial household head / agrarian and social authority

SETTHI: wealthy merchant-financier in urban-commercial networks

KASSAKA: cultivator; category contained unequal holdings and dependence

KAMMIKAS / ARTISANS: specialised production and guild-like association

DASA-KAMMAKARA: dependent and unfree labour categories

RENUNCIANTS: outside household ideal yet dependent on lay patronage

Wealth could raise influence without automatically cancelling ritual hierarchy.

Use social terms with source and context; do not make them modern classes.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Women, household power and exclusion

TEXTUAL NORMS: patriliney, marriage control and gendered duties

BUDDHIST/JAINA MATERIAL: nuns, donors, householders and debates over admission

MATERIAL SILENCE: archaeology rarely identifies gender without context

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Agency existed within unequal institutions; elite women cannot stand for all women.

Renunciation opened spaces but preserved hierarchy and dependence.

VERDICT: recover variation without inventing equality or total seclusion.



## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: Shramana challenge and social response

RITUAL COST + URBAN CHANGE + SOCIAL MOBILITY + SUFFERING

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Buddhist, Jaina, Ajivika and other renunciant critiques

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ethics, karma, rebirth, non-injury, discipline and new communities

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merchant and ruler patronage + monastic institutions + doctrinal competition

LIMIT: shramana movements challenged hierarchy unevenly, not all social ranking.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: Material evidence: pottery, coins, towns and routes

NBPW -> consumption and early-historic settlement horizon

FORTIFICATIONS -> defence, labour mobilisation and political investment

PUNCH-MARKED COINS -> monetised exchange in selected circuits

CRAFT AREAS -> specialised production and urban demand

SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY -> links villages, towns and political centres

RIVERS/ROADS -> movement of goods, armies, pilgrims and information

No single marker proves a city, ruler, varna or religious community.

Use convergence among artefact, layer, text and regional sequence.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Change and continuity across polity and society

CHANGE: larger states | towns | taxation | coin use | renunciant institutions

CONTINUITY: kinship | agrarian household | ritual hierarchy | local communities

TENSION: monarchy vs gana | wealth vs status | norm vs practice

REGIONALITY: Ganga plains != north-west != Deccan trajectories

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The Buddha age was accelerated restructuring, not a total social revolution.

Best answers connect political capacity, economy, hierarchy and ethical critique.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Examiner-ready Buddha-age answer spine

INTRO: define the sixth-fifth century BCE core within a wider early-historic range.

BODY 1: source hierarchy and chronology caution

BODY 2: territorial states, institutions and agrarian extraction

BODY 3: towns, trade, householders, artisans and labour

BODY 4: varna norm, lived hierarchy, gender and shramana critique

COUNTER: regional variation, composite texts and material-evidence limits

CONCLUSION: state, economy and society changed together but unevenly.

WRITE: process -> named evidence -> social effect -> qualification.